

Q What is a birth plan? Do I need one and, if so, when should I write it?

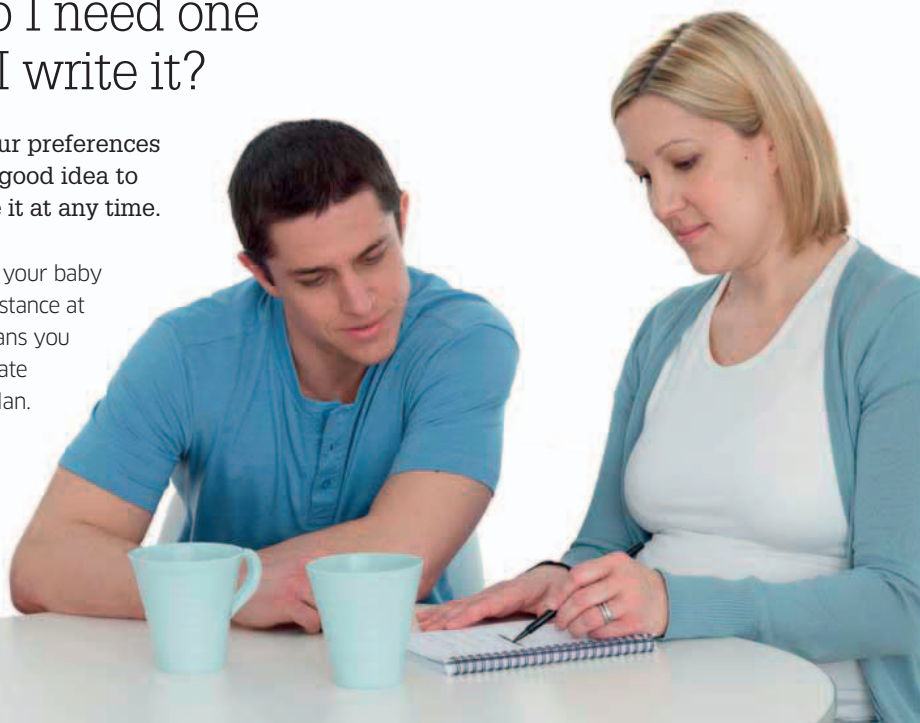
A birth plan is your opportunity to put down on paper your preferences for labor and birth. You don't have to have one, but it's a good idea to at least think through what you would like. You can create it at any time.

A birth plan is a means of thinking through what's important to you about the process of having your baby and to highlight any queries you might have for your doctor. It can include anything and everything, from what music you'd like to have playing to the type of pain relief you'd prefer. You can start writing a birth plan as soon as you like, and amend it and add to it as your pregnancy progresses, gathering wisdom and ideas from doctors, medical staff, family, friends, and other moms-to-be. It is a good idea to remember, though, that labor does not always go as planned; you need to be flexible in the

event that you or your baby need medical assistance at any time that means you may need to deviate from your birth plan.

Your preferences

Go through your wishes with your partner.



STRUCTURING YOUR BIRTH PLAN

Use the following headings and ideas as a guide to writing your birth plan. Remember that it can be more or less detailed than this.



» **My birth environment:** Where you want to labor and give birth; what music (if any) you want playing; any other ways in which you want to set the right mood.



» **Emotional support and your personal care:** Who you want with you and how you want them to support you; whether you want your birth partner near your head, or at the birth end; whether you want photos of you in labor.



» **Positions and props:** My preferred position for birth, whether or not you want to move around during labor, and whether or not you want to use a ball or chair and so on.



» **Pain relief and physical care:** Whether you'd like to have pain relief and if so, what kind; if there are any forms of pain relief you want to avoid; whether or not it is OK to have an episiotomy if your doctor thinks it would ease your labor.



» **Taking care of my baby during birth:** Whether you want to stay upright and mobile while your doctor is checking your baby's heart rate; if you have any objections to your baby's heart rate being monitored continuously.



» **Assisted birth:** If you are given a choice, whether or not you have a preference for forceps or vacuum extraction; whether you are OK to be given medicine to increase the strength of your contractions.



» **The moment of birth:** Whether or not you'd like your baby placed on your tummy; who holds your baby first; whether you or your partner would like to announce the sex; who will cut the umbilical cord, and if you'd like to delay cord-cutting.



» **My placenta:** Whether you want to deliver the placenta naturally; whether you'd like to see your placenta, or even keep it.



» **Taking care of my newborn:** Your wishes for feeding and skin-to-skin contact; who holds the baby while you deliver the placenta or have any stitches.



» **Telling the world:** Who you'd like told first about the birth and even in what order; whether there are certain people you'd like to tell yourself, or whether you're happy to let your birth partner spread the news to everyone.



» **Emergencies:** If you're having a home birth, which hospital you want to go to (if you have a choice) in an emergency; if you're having your baby at an independent birthing center, where you'd like to be transferred if you have an emergency.



» **Special requirements:** Whether English is your first language; if you need a sign language interpreter; if you have special dietary requirements; if you or your partner has special needs; if you would like certain religious customs to be observed.